



10 – Brand Guidelines

*The visual identity for The Charles Blow Show. Derived from an editorial, magazine-style design direction: light "paper" canvas, near-black ink, a single warm **ember** accent, a high-contrast serif for headlines paired with a clean grotesque sans for UI. Authoritative, literate, warm, modern.*

Use this as the single source of truth for the website, lower-thirds, thumbnails, social templates, and decks. Implemented in code at [web/app/globals.css](#) (design tokens) and [web/components/logo.tsx](#) (the mark).

1. Brand attributes

Incisive · Principled · Warm · Unflinching · Literate.

The look should feel like a serious independent newsroom that a person actually wants to read — editorial, not cable-news loud; confident, not cold.

2. Logo

Three forms, one system:

FORM	USE
Monogram "CB"	App icon, favicon, social avatars, lower-third bug, clip end-cards
Wordmark	"The Charles Blow Show" — site header, footers, decks
Lockup	Monogram + wordmark, horizontal — primary signature

The mark: an ink rounded-square containing serif **"CB"** with a short **ember byline rule** beneath — evoking a byline/underline, the editorial signature of a columnist.

Clear space: keep padding equal to the height of the "C" around the lockup. **Minimum size:** monogram no smaller than 24px; wordmark legible at ≥120px wide.

Don'ts: don't recolor the mark outside the palette · don't stretch or rotate · don't add shadows/gradients to the letters · don't place the wordmark on a busy photo without a scrim.

3. Color palette

TOKEN	HEX	ROLE
Paper	#FBFAF6	Primary background (warm white)
Surface	#FFFFFF	Cards, raised panels
Ink	#14161D	Primary text, dark buttons/surfaces, nav
Ink Soft	#2A2D36	Secondary dark / borders on dark
Muted	#6C7077	Metadata, captions, author • date
Line	#E7E3D9	Hairline dividers & card borders
Ember	#E8552D	Primary accent — links, eyebrows, focus, CTAs
Ember Dark	#C8432C	Accent hover/pressed
Ember Tint	#FBE9E2	Soft accent backgrounds, badges

Usage rules

- **Ember is a spice, not a sauce** — small doses: category eyebrows, the "live" dot, focus rings, one primary button per view.
- Body text is **Ink on Paper**; never ember on paper for long copy.
- Dark sections invert: **Paper text on Ink** with ember accents.
- Maintain **WCAG AA** contrast (Ink on Paper passes; ember is for accents/large text, not small body).

4. Typography

ROLE	TYPEFACE	NOTES
Display / Headlines	Newsreader (serif)	Editorial, high-contrast. Lowercase headlines with a period ("Latest news.") are a signature device. Weights 400–600; italics for emphasis.
UI / Body / Labels	Inter (sans)	Nav, buttons, metadata, body.
Category eyebrows	Inter	UPPERCASE, letter-spaced, 12px, muted or ember.

Type scale (web): Display 48–72 · H2 32–40 · H3 20–24 · Body 16–18 · Meta/Label 12–14. **Rules:** serif for headlines only; sans for everything functional. Generous line-height on body (1.6). One accent weight, not many.

5. Components & motifs

- **Cards:** white surface, **Line** hairline border, 14px radius, optional media block on top.
- **Category eyebrow:** small uppercase label above titles (ember or muted).
- **Byline meta:** **Author** • **Date** in muted sans — the editorial fingerprint.
- **Buttons:** primary = Ink fill, Paper text, with a trailing →; accent = Ember fill; ghost = Line border. Subscribe button pairs a dark block with an arrow tile (per the reference).
- **Section headers:** serif, lowercase, trailing period, with prev/next **arrow controls** on the right for carousels.
- **Media blocks:** where real photography isn't available yet, use ember↔ink **duotone gradients** as intentional placeholders.
- **Live dot:** small pulsing ember circle for the live segment.

6. Voice (verbal identity)

- **Plainspoken and precise.** Short, declarative. Say the quiet part.
- **Warm authority.** Smart friend at the table, not a lecturer.
- **Action-oriented.** End on "What Now?" — leave people equipped, not anxious.
- Sentence case in UI; lowercase-with-period for editorial section titles.

7. Application

SURFACE	DIRECTION
Website	Paper canvas, editorial cards, ember accents (see web/)
YouTube thumbnails	High-contrast: Blow's face + ember title bar + serif phrase
Lower-thirds	Ink bar, Paper text, ember rule + CB bug
Clip template	Paper or Ink caption band, ember progress/keyword highlight, CB end-card
Substack / newsletter	Serif headlines, ink body, ember links, byline metas
Social avatars	CB monogram on ink

8. Tokens (for engineering)

Defined as Tailwind v4 theme tokens in [web/app/globals.css](#) :

```
--color-paper · --color-surface · --color-ink · --color-ink-soft  
--color-muted · --color-line · --color-ember · --color-ember-dark · --color-ember-tint  
--font-serif (Newsreader) · --font-sans (Inter)
```

Utilities follow automatically: [bg-paper](#) , [text-ink](#) , [text-ember](#) , [border-line](#) , [font-serif](#) , etc.